now being proven or refined by population archaeogenetics, a field whose impact on ancient history may end up being as significant as radiocarbon dating (1949).[52]

The OIT was motivated by bad politics rather than by good scholarship. Beneath its shallow veneer of science lay an insecure and parochial Hindutva project all too vested in proving that Vedic texts and Sanskrit were primordially indigenous to the subcontinent. If Hinduism could be shown to be a 'native' religion, it would foster Hindu pride and nationalism and render Islam and Christianity 'invader' religions. However, to the extent the Rig Veda, Sanskrit, and priestly fire rituals are seen as foundations of modern Hinduism, to that extent Hinduism too, it turns out, is an 'invader' religion, arriving with the Aryans from Central Asia. As these facts trickle down, it'll be interesting to watch how Hindutva ideologues devise new tricks to preserve the nativist claims and supremacist beliefs that underpin their project of Hindu nationalism.

The Harappan within Us

Many modern Hindus revere the Sanskritic Vedas as the fountainhead of their religion, but the Harappan substrate that lives on today is both older and arguably more pervasive, especially in what we might call 'folk Hinduism', with its mother goddesses, guardian deities, reverence for certain trees and animals and perhaps even spiritual-meditative practices. Harappan female figures in terracotta, possibly goddesses, 'with full breasts, rounded hips, and the hipline belt or girdle called the *mekhalā*', resemble the *yakshis*, symbols of fertility, on the Buddhist stupas of Bharhut and Sanchi, 'with the same well-endowed figure and the same hipline *mekhalā*'.[53] Conch shells appear at many Harappan sites, though we can only guess what purpose they served. In his splendid book, *Early Indians* (2018), Tony Joseph has noted many material continuities, too, and how 'the way in which we carry on the traditions of Harappan Civilization are too many to count'.

> The way houses are built around courtyards; the bullock carts; the importance of bangles and the way they are worn [as in the famous bronze figurine, 'the dancing girl', a style still common in Kutch]; the manner in which trees are worshipped and the sacredness of the peepul tree in particular; the ubiquitous Indian cooking pot and the kulladh; the cultic